Two Kinds of Control

From Foucault's Discipline to Deleuze's Societies of Control

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For most of the modern era, power worked by putting you somewhere. You moved through a sequence of enclosed institutions — family, then school, then the army or the job, with the hospital or the prison waiting if things went wrong. Each had walls, a schedule, and a set of rules that stopped at the door. You finished one and entered the next. Michel Foucault called this **discipline**.[1]

In 1990, before the web existed, a French philosopher named Gilles Deleuze wrote five pages arguing that this arrangement was already ending, and that something harder to see was replacing it. He called it **control**.[2] Three of his images are worth attention in our course.

The mold and the modulation. An enclosure is a mold: it stamps you into shape, then releases you. Control is a modulation — a cast that keeps reshaping itself, adjusting continuously. Nothing is ever finished. The diploma gives way to perpetual retraining; the exam gives way to permanent assessment.

The individual and the "dividual." Discipline knew you by your signature and your number — a whole person, filed in a place. Control does not need the whole person. It needs your parts: your purchases, your location, your dwell time, your score. You are divisible, and the pieces are recombined into markets and samples. What grants or refuses you access is no longer a guard at a gate but a code.

The mole and the serpent. The mole burrows through fixed tunnels — enclosed, discontinuous, always starting over. The serpent coils continuously through open ground, everywhere and nowhere in particular. Deleuze ends the essay by observing that a serpent's coils are more intricate than a mole's burrows.

A question to hold. Discipline forbids. Control does not need to forbid anything, because it can simply make one path frictionless and the others tedious.

How would you know if you were being controlled by something that never once told you no?

Further Reading: See Shoshana Zuboff, "You Are Now Remotely Controlled."[3]

Footnotes

[1] Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison* (1975). The source of the disciplinary model Deleuze is revising.

[2] Gilles Deleuze, "Postscript on the Societies of Control," *October* 59 (Winter 1992): 3–7. Five pages; the whole essay.

[3] Shoshana Zuboff, "You Are Now Remotely Controlled," *The New York Times*, January 24, 2019.